her inherent grain makes her different," Shah says. "There are so many layers to women. She is no longer an accessory." *Human* sees two women in the spotlight. Kirti Kulhari (*Four More Shots Please!*, 2019-) plays Dr Saira Sabharwal, Dr Nath's protégé who gradually finds herself at odds with her idol.

A 10-episode series with women at the helm, *Human* no longer seems like an anomaly, and it is, in part, thanks to this trend of increased representation that Shah enjoyed the busiest spell of her career last year. "Even earlier, my work was appreciated, but it didn't translate into roles or offers," says Shah. "There were offers that came my way, but I chose to say no. I came to understand that the kind of work I have done doesn't come every day. That's no longer the case. I am finally doing what I wanted to do. Now I have offers, many of which put me in the centre."

If the pandemic doesn't play spoilsport, Shah will be seen in four more projects in 2022—*Darlings* with Alia Bhatt, *Jalsa* with Vidya Balan, *Doctor G* with Ayushmann Khurrana, and *Three of Us*, an Avinash Arun-directed drama with Jaideep Ahlawat and Swanand Kirkire. Equally anticipated is the second season of *Delhi Crime*. "Finally, people are writing scripts for me. Filmmakers think I have the capacity to carry a show or film on my shoulders," says Shah. Better late than never. ■

–Suhani Singh

ENTERTAINMENT

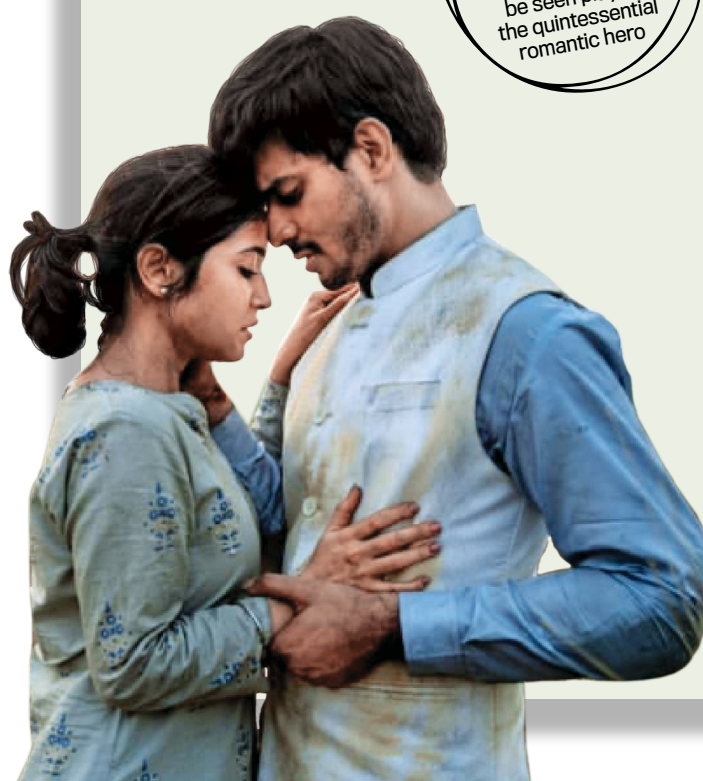
MOST WANTED

It's not just characters in his shows who are vying for his attention, Bollywood now wants more of **Tahir Raj Bhasin's** time and talent

Tahir Raj Bhasin's eight-year cinematic journey has seen him play a 1940s movie star (*Manto*, 2018), a celebrated cricketer (*'83*, 2021) and a dreaded baddie (*Mardaani*, 2014). The one thing missing from this résumé was the clichéd role of a quintessential romantic hero. Finally, this January, he gets to play that part, not once but twice—in *Yeh Kaali Kaali Ankhein* (Netflix) and *Ranjish Hi Sahi* (Voot Select).

In *YKKA*, we see a woman's love for Bhasin's character border on fatal attraction. Playing "an ordinary guy caught up in extraordinary circumstances", Bhasin describes the show as a "genre bender". Packed with dark comedy and Bollywood pulp, *YKKA* is what the actor even calls a "driller—a drama romantic thriller". The title, says Bhasin, puts a twist on the meaning of the hit track from *Baazigar* (1993). Here, the dark eyes allude to "the power structures that look on to you". Meanwhile, in *Ranjish Hi Sahi*, created by Mahesh Bhatt, he plays a filmmaker in the 1970s whose affair with an actress (Amala Paul) jeopardises his marriage and career.

In his latest, Yeh Kaali Kaali Ankhein and Ranjish hi Sahi, **TAHIR RAJ BHASIN** will be seen playing the quintessential romantic hero



For Bhasin, these two projects signal a new beginning, one where he is in the spotlight, not the margins. In Nitesh Tiwari's *Chhichhore* (2019) he was the cool dude on campus and, more recently, in *'83*, he stepped into the shoes of Sunil Gavaskar, the senior, quieter member of the World Cup-winning team. For Bhasin, more than the screen time, what is crucial is "how the part pivots the story? What happens when the character comes in?"

This reflects in his debut film, *Mardaani*, too. The deftness with which he had played a menacing nemesis to Rani Mukerji's supercop had won him much praise. Bhasin, though, soon found himself refusing a slew of darker parts he was being offered. It was a risky move in an industry where one's talent is often equated with one's visibility on screen. "I knew if I had to grow, I had to be vulnerable in the choices I made. In the long run, it has proven to be beneficial," he says.

Bhasin may not have yet cemented his place in the leading man club, but he's on his way. His next, *Loop Lapeta*, a remake of German thriller *Run Lola Run* (1998), sees him star opposite Taapsee Pannu. Part of the Yash Raj Films Talent roster, Bhasin is inspired just by being in the premises of YRF's office in Mumbai. "You walk into the elevator and you may meet Ranveer [Singh]. You walk out and you are likely to run into Ayushmann [Khurrana]," he says. "It keeps your game up." ■

–Suhani Singh